

proposal to the Delhi Municipal Corporation when they're done.

KITES serves not just its students: the school also aims at utilising its resources for the good of the community, and their IT labs are used to carry out several projects for the community.

Towards Employment

KITES began with a one-year certification course, primarily for students who have graduated from school. The course is also open to young adults who have been unable to attend school.

Students who take up this course are mostly aged between 15 and 19. The course is vocational in nature, in which the students are taught basic courses for six months, and then in the next six months, they have to choose between four electives—on the designing front, they choose between Web Designing and DTP, and for accounting, they choose between Financial Accounting and Office Automation according to the certificate they want.

For accounting, they receive training in MS Office and Tally—an accounting software—besides other related office automation. And in Web Design, they learn to use software such as DreamWeaver, as well as DTP—a programme that includes Corel-Draw, PageMaker and Photoshop. Besides, there is a six month certification in hardware (networking, hardware assembling and card repairing). These courses prepare the children for gainful employment.

Later, the school decided to teach the children to use computers at the high school level. Today, children are trained, at the outset, in school and they have the option of continuing with the cer-



A room with a view—inside KITES

tificate course if they do not find employment after graduation. The school certificate course, called the KSSC—Katha School Support Certificate—is initiated in the sixth grade, and continues up to the ninth grade. This certification runs parallel to their regular school curriculum, and the children are taught to use the Windows operating system as well as the Internet. These students also use animation software—Flash and Photoshop Illustrator for graphics. In their tenth grade, the students are required to create a documentary using digital cameras.

Effective Teaching

Most of the teachers at KITES have IT certification themselves. To keep up with developments in software, the school conducts a 60 hour training in the months of May and June, where new faculty members are familiarised with course work. In addition, there is a week-long training prior to the winter break in December. The training focuses on capacity and curriculum building where the administration reviews work done in the academic year, updates syllabus and reviews and solves any setbacks that they have faced.

“Language is sometimes a barrier,” says Rana. “Most students speak and know only Hindi, whereas the software is in English. We aid them in understanding some terms by what it does.” The children learn from each other, and this diminishes the hurdles that language creates. All in all, the enthusiasm that the children show overcomes many hitches they face.

It's Not All About The Money

The aim is to allow the children to experience technology by

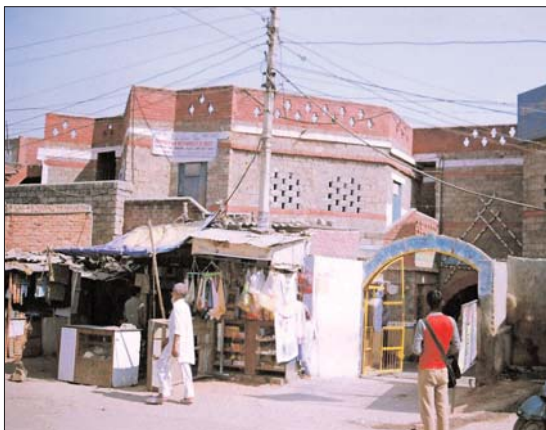
themselves. The children are not exactly taught, but rather, are guided through their projects. Each child is required to conceive of, visualise, implement and present the projects assigned to him or her. A child, as a result, gains tremendous confidence in his ability to carry forth on his own.

“Just a basic education does not qualify the children professionally. Technology is easy to handle with constant practice, and it bridges the divide between where they come from and where they aspire to be,” says Parvinder. With certification, they are equipped to work in the capacity of Web designers and data operators, a profile that is otherwise inaccessible to them. Once they are certified, employment is easy. KITES also holds a “job mela”—a week-long workshop—once the students have completed the course, where they provide them with career counselling and inform them about vacancies. The school has had success in placing 90 per cent of their students since inception. A job for the students is the end goal of the certification program, and the administration perseveres in its search until a student is successfully placed.

While the cost of such courses run into the thousands of rupees at private institutes, KITES only charges a small fee. Besides, the school has other incentives for the students. “We have no prerequisites during registration. But our criteria are of different sorts altogether. We award the students for tasks completed, which translate into scholarships. For example, we take twenty rupees off a student's fees if he or she is regular. Good work is rewarded with ten rupees off their fees,” says Anant Singh Rana, a teacher at KITES.

The work done by these young adults and school students has produced a noticeable difference in the community. The fact that the youth from impoverished houses in the Govindpuri area are earning produces a ripple effect, where the residents want to improve as a community. With constant support from their sponsors, KITES hopes to carry forward their initiative to the rest of the city. ☒

jjyotsna_rege@thinkdigit.com



At Govindpuri—the KITES facade understates what lies within